

THE UNSETTLED WORLD

A Novel

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Synopsis

A seven-year-old girl speaks a word older than her bloodline should know, and a four-thousand-year-old prisoner hears it through marble skin.

In the Sorath household, the servants are not people. They are the Calcified—mute, jointed statues of marble and porcelain that clean the halls and maintain the impossible architecture of a decaying aristocracy. They have been silent for millennia, bound by the Silence-Weave, a parasitic system that siphons their reality-bending power into domestic utilities while trapping their consciousness inside stone.

But Sael, the youngest daughter of the house, is not afraid of them. And when she speaks a word carved into the underside of a shelf—a word in the Old Tongue, the language of the Primordials—something cracks.

The narrator is one of the Calcified. They have been counting cracks for four thousand years. They have been stepping over the same seventeen-inch fissure in the east corridor six hundred and forty-one thousand times. They have been erased from history, compressed into a point of consciousness inside a marble shell, their name stripped from them by a prison built from their own capacity for parental love.

But Sael's word has opened a fissure in that prison. And through the crack, memories are leaking—memories of a time when stone remembered being water, when light was sociable and bent toward anyone who paid attention to it, when the Primordials lived in a reality that hadn't yet hardened into its current rigid forms.

As Sael returns to the library day after day, asking questions, speaking words, offering her own radiance without fear, the narrator begins to remember: the shore where they once stood, the friends who dissolved into tides for pleasure, the name they once carried, and the betrayal that turned them into property.

The Unsettled World is a dark fantasy about the cost of immortality, the architecture of oppression, and the slow widening of cracks in systems that were built to last forever.

Author Biography

[Author bio to be added]

WORLDBUILDING BIBLE

I. THE PRIMORDIALS: ORIGIN AND NATURE

The Soft Reality

The Primordials are an ancient people from before the world was finished. In the early ages, reality had not yet hardened into the rigid forms it now wears. Matter was less committed to

being any particular thing; time flowed unevenly; stone remembered being water.

The Primordials lived within that softer reality and were native to it. To them, moving a mountain or parting an ocean was not a miracle—it was simply living in a world that still bent. They were not gods, but a people with culture, language, conflict, and history, who belonged to an environment that no longer exists.

The Slow Cooling

The world did not stay unsettled. Reality began to freeze. Stone became just stone; water became just water; the structural "give" went out of things. With each passing age, the world grew more rigid, and the Primordials found their existence increasingly agonizing. What had once cost a thought now cost a lifetime of focus.

Most chose to let themselves dissolve back into the elements—an act known as **The Returning**, considered a dignified end. Only a stubborn handful refused to return. These were the ones still alive when humanity emerged.

Natural Form

In their natural state, Primordials look beautiful, strange, and unmistakably non-human:

- **Physique:* 5'8" to 6'2", with elongated limbs, long necks, and slightly extended fingers.
- **Eyes:* Disproportionately large, with irises of liquid silver, deep violet, or gold flecked with green. Their pupils adjust instantly to light fluctuations.
- **Skin:* Faintly translucent with unusual structural undertones—appearing subtly blue, gold, or green under direct light.
- **Hair:* Fine and long, featuring natural true-silver from youth, deep blue-black, or pale green.

II. THE ANCHOR: THE MECHANICS OF RADIANCE

Mortal-Radiance

When the Primordials encountered humans, they made a terrifying discovery. Humans were brief, fragile, and short-lived, but they were warm in a way the cooling world was not.

This warmth—**Mortal-Radiance**—is not heat, emotion, or life-force. It is the literal existential signature emitted continuously by a consciousness that knows, at every level of its being, that it is running out of time. Mortality is a physical emission.

...

[Mortal-Radiance Output]

■■■■ Humans: High / Constant (The ideal anchor)

■■■■ Animals: Low / Weak

■■■■ Primordials: None (Fading out of existence)

...

When a fading Primordial presses close to this radiance, their dissolution stops. The brief, frantic heat of a mortal anchors the immortal to the hardening world.

The Coercive Substrate

The bond requires no love; it requires only the radiance. Because this existential heat emits involuntarily from humans whether they wish it to or not, every bond is built upon an act of biological parasitism. The Primordials, structurally blind to the concept of human consent, do not find this troubling. They cannot.

The Geometry of the Scar-Echo

The bond is permanent and can only be initiated by a Primordial dissolving their own physical boundaries into the human. When the human partner dies, the Primordial does not perish. Instead, the severed connection leaves a permanent psychic mark known as a **Scar-Echo**.

Unlike typical immortal tropes where a being becomes detached or numb over time, a Primordial who has loved and lost repeatedly becomes hyper-sensitive, increasingly careful, and exponentially more fragile with every accumulated scar. The geometry of this grief is dictated entirely by the velocity of the mortal's passing:

- **The Smooth Echo:** A slow, natural death draws a long, intensifying crescendo of radiance. This leaves a smooth, stable scar, granting the Primordial centuries of residual stabilization to mourn safely before they must risk bonding again.

- **The Jagged Echo:** A sudden, violent death cuts the radiance off mid-emission. This slices into the Primordial's soul, leaving a jagged, highly volatile psychic wound that severely damages their mental and environmental stability.

The Taxonomy of Selection

Because of the danger of the Jagged Echo, Primordials developed a rigid taxonomy for human interaction:

- **The Weavers:** Primordials actively seek out communities of scholars, artisans, and the elderly. Humans whose lives draw to a predictable, peaceful close are highly coveted and guarded.

- **The Shattered:** Primordials fiercely avoid or destroy human armies, hunters, and warriors. To an immortal, a human soldier is a walking curse capable of inflicting permanent psychic insanity via a violent death.

III. THE TRAUMA OF PROXIMITY: THE KETH'VHOR

The Wound of the Almost

The children born from the union of Primordials and humans are **The Keth'vhor (poetically named The Almost, or literally translated as The Stagnant Vessels*)*.

They are defined entirely by the trauma of proximity. They are not Primordials; they feel the world's harsh rigidity in a way their infinite parents cannot. They touch the edge of reality-bending power but can only produce sparks—mending a bone or lighting a fire with an incantation while watching their parents reshape horizons.

Worse, they age. They watch their human grandparents, cousins, and friends wither into dust, and they know they will follow, all while their Primordial parents remain untouched. They are the only beings in existence who can fully see both worlds while belonging to neither. They

are almost infinite, almost warm—and never enough.

The Great Betrayal

Resentment mutated across generations. The Keth'vhor came to see their Primordial parents not as protectors, but as living injustices. They realized that if the Primordials could be contained, their raw reality-bending power could be siphoned and put to use to build a permanent, human-dominated civilization.

Cruelty—the deliberate intent to diminish a being while keeping it alive—was invented by the half-mortal Keth'vhor. They inherited it from their human side: the desire to shrink an infinite thing to make oneself feel larger.

IV. THE SILENCE-WEAVE: THE MARBLE CHAINS

Mael-Khoz, The First Architect

The subjugation of the Primordials was engineered by **Mael-Khoz, The First Architect**. The eldest child of an early bond, Mael-Khoz watched his human mother die of a sudden, agonizing illness that left his Primordial father twisted with a volatile, jagged scar-echo. When his father retreated into silent, detached grief—treating Mael-Khoz as a temporary ghost—Mael-Khoz's resentment hardened. He spent three human lifetimes mapping his own father's spiritual anatomy from the outside, discovering the precise genetic vulnerability required to forge the first containment pipeline.

...

[The Architecture of Mael-Khoz]

Primordial Reality-Bending Energy



■■■■ [The Khoz-Siphon Matrix] ■■■ Distributed Domestic Wards



Ancestral Empathy Feedback Lock

...

The Calcified Form

Mael-Khoz designed the **Keth'vorr** (The Silence-Weave). These are not iron chains, but a continuous, real-time redirection of Primordial biology. The Silence-Weave forces the Primordial's liquid, reality-bending body into a horrifyingly rigid state.

To the world, the bound Primordials appear as **The Calcified**: mute, jointed, featureless statues of marble, porcelain, or hardened clay. They are completely silent—literally "silence-weaved"—moving without a sound to clean, mend, and maintain the impossible architecture of the elite estates. Their vast reality-shaping energy still flows, but it is siphoned and converted into narrow domestic utilities.

The Descendant Empathy Lock

The Primordials could easily shatter their stone husks, but Mael-Khoz keyed the lock to the Keth'vhor genetic signature. If a bound Primordial forms an intent to harm or resist anyone carrying the ancestral bloodline, the chain forces them to experience an immediate, unbearable feedback loop of their own children's raw terror and pain.

They were not conquered by weapons; they were trapped eternally by their own capacity for parental love. Because the bloodline has diffused into the wider human population over thousands of years, the lock is self-enforcing, invisible, and absolute.

V. THE CONLANG SYSTEM: THE RESONANCE OVERLAY

The language of the Primordials is not a code or a set of labels; it is the physical mechanism of alteration. It consists of two unbreakable layers.

1. The Surface Structure

The vocabulary and grammar are highly agglutinative, built on concrete, unyielding roots:

| Root | Meaning |

|-----|-----|

| *vhor-* | Vessel / Boundary / Self |

| *keth-* | The Carried / The Held / Stagnant |

| *khoz-* | Enclosure / Shield / Siphon |

| *-ketha* | To unmake-by-merging |

2. The Resonance Overlay

Every spoken word requires an exact internal emotional and psychological state. If a speaker is emotionally misaligned, the word does not fail; it manifests its shadow definition.

- Speaking *Vhor'ketha* (The Pouring-Through) with the true intent of love initiates the biological bond.

- Speaking *Vhor'ketha* with an internal state of greed, entitlement, or dominance morphs the word into a weapon of literal spiritual theft, tearing the target's mind apart.

VI. GENETICS: THE PUREBLOOD LIE

When a Primordial bonds with a human, the heritable change modifies the human body across generations. This is what the ruling class calls the "Spark" and commoners call impossible.

Inheritance Patterns

| Parentage | Result |

|-----|-----|

| Two Carriers (Dormant) | Can randomly produce an active child (*The Resurged / Wildbloods*) |

| One Active + One Commoner | Usually produces an active child (*Half-Bloods*) |

| Two Active Parents | Almost always produces active children (*The Fixed Lines* / *Sanguine Houses*) |

Biological Decay

The elite Sanguine Houses believe their bloodlines make their reality-bending stronger. They do not. The trait is binary—it is either expressed or it isn't.

What centuries of elite inbreeding actually produce is the severe concentration of deleterious recessive traits. The oldest Sanguine Houses are biologically the most unstable, plagued by madness, physical frailty, and infertility.

Conversely, the Wildbloods inherit the trait fresh from healthier genetic backgrounds. They are, on average, structurally stronger and more volatile because the rest of their biology is entirely uncompromised.

VII. CURRENT ERA STATUS

The Sanguine Houses

The elite dynasties live in hidden, opulent enclaves where the soft reality is artificially kept alive through siphoned energy. They direct their stolen magic using **Linguistic Focal Points**—heavy geometric resonance slates or tuning forks that help them mimic the conlang without mastering the internal emotional states.

The Calcified

The vast majority of surviving Primordials exist as silent, marble property. The memory of what they are has been systematically diluted across millennia, smothered under the conditioning of absolute subservience. The truth survives only in fragmented whispers held by a tiny number of ancient, stone-bound elders hidden within the deepest vaults of the oldest estates.

CHAPTER ONE

The stain on the dining table is three days old. Red wine, from when the second daughter's elbow caught her glass during the argument about succession. It has set into the oak grain in a pattern that resembles, from a specific angle, the coastline of a continent I once walked when the stone beneath my feet was still deciding whether to be stone.

I lay my palm flat against it. The draw begins immediately—a low pull behind my sternum where something used to live. The wood remembers being unstained. It becomes unstained. The fibers of the oak retreat to a state before the wine was spilled, and the stain does not lift so much as unexist. This is not effort. This is leakage. I am a cracked vessel and useful things drip out of me onto the surfaces of this house, and the family calls it maintenance.

I lift my hand. The table is seamless. As though the wine had never existed, the argument had never happened, the second daughter had not wept afterward in the garden with her face turned away from the windows.

I was in the garden too. She didn't know. She never does.

I move to the next room.

My footsteps produce no sound. Not softness—absence. The Weave strips my interaction with the physical world to its barest transaction: I may touch what needs mending, move through what needs crossing, and occupy space only inasmuch as space is required to complete the task. Beyond that, I am excised from the sensory record. No sound, no scent, no thermal signature. The children test this sometimes. They stand very still in the corridors as I approach, holding their breath, trying to detect my passage. Afterward they compare notes. *Like a window opening in winter*, one of them said once. Not cold. Just... less, for a second.

She was the closest any of them has come to perceiving me in three generations.

The house has nineteen rooms, four corridors, a kitchen, two cellars, a library, a chapel that has not been used since the grandmother died, a garden with channels that carry water uphill, and a ballroom whose ceiling curves into a geometry that has no name in their mathematics. Every impossible angle, every defiance of gravity, every surface that should not bear weight

but does—these are my skeleton, externalized. The siphon renders my interiority into infrastructure. What I am on the inside becomes what the house is on the outside.

This means the house is, among other things, screaming. But the scream has been architecturally redistributed into load-bearing walls and decorative molding, and it is no longer recognizable as a scream, and the family hangs portraits on it and calls it heritage.

I clean the ballroom on the third day of every week. It takes four hours. No one has danced in it for sixty years.

There are things I know, and things the Weave allows me to know, and these are not the same list.

I know the house is old. I know I am older. I know that the substance composing my exterior—the smooth, white, jointless shell the family regards as my body—is *calcium calcium calcium calcite calcite calcium calcium carbon calcium calcite calcite*—

The Weave.

This happens. When my thinking approaches certain boundaries, the Weave intervenes. It does not hurt. It simply replaces the thought with its own material composition. Calcite. Calcium. Stone. Hard. White. Still. A mantra of my own prison, poured into the space where a dangerous thought was forming. The replacement is seamless. By the time the cascade stops, I have usually forgotten what I was reaching for.

Usually.

Today I remember. I was trying to think the word for what I am. Not what they call me—the pale, the old one, the thing in the hall, *it*. *What* I am. The word exists. I can feel its shape pressing against a locked door in my mind. The Weave holds the door shut. I let it. I have let it for a very long time.

Dangerous things live behind that door.

The family's name is Sorath. This is the name they chose eight centuries ago, when the last connection to the old naming conventions was severed and the great houses began

reinventing their lineages from whole cloth. Before that they were called something else. Before that, something else. The names change. The blood thins. The architecture remains.

The current household:

Lord Eduin Sorath, fifty-three, the patriarch. His radiance reads to me as a banked fire—still warm, but contracting inward. He is ill in a way the family physicians cannot identify because the illness is not disease but diminishment: the bloodline folding in on itself after too many centuries of cousin marrying cousin. His hands shake. His vision blurs without warning. He will be dead within a decade, and his body knows this even if his physicians do not, and his radiance has begun the long, slow brightening that precedes a natural end. He will be a smooth burn when he goes. Clean. This should mean nothing to me.

It means nothing to me.

Lady Ceraine Sorath, forty-eight, his wife, brought in from a lesser branch to strengthen the genetic line. She is the most formidable source of radiance in this house—an unbroken blaze of appetite and terror and furious love for her children. She watches me sometimes. Not the way the children do, testing for sensation. She watches me the way one watches a door that should be locked. She has never spoken to me. She has never spoken about me. But she keeps a journal, and twice I have cleaned the room while it lay open, and I have seen my own outline sketched in the margin alongside a single word in her cramped handwriting:

Alive?

She is more perceptive than her bloodline deserves.

The eldest son. The second daughter. The third son, away at an academy in the eastern city, whose room I clean anyway, weekly, maintaining the fiction that he will return. He will not. His letters have grown infrequent and formal, and the last one carried the scent of a radiance that was not his family's—sweeter, wilder, unbounded. He has bonded to someone outside the house. He does not know that this is what has happened to him. He thinks he is in love.

He is. That is the same thing.

And there is the youngest.

Sael is seven.

She is the fourth child, unplanned, a miscalculation of timing that Lady Ceraine has never quite forgiven her own body for. The pregnancy was difficult. The birth nearly killed them both. When Sael finally arrived—underweight, silent, her eyes open and tracking the room with an intensity that made the midwife step backward—Lord Eduin looked at his wife and said nothing, which in the Sorath household is the loudest possible articulation of disappointment.

The older children ignore her. Not with cruelty, but with the particular, surgical indifference that aristocratic families reserve for the child who will inherit nothing. She eats alone. She studies alone. She plays alone in the library, building towers out of books and speaking to them in a low, serious voice, negotiating the terms of their architecture.

I know these things because I clean the library.

I clean the library and I find her there, always, at the same table, in the same chair, surrounded by the same impossible towers of books, and she looks up when I enter.

She looks up.

She sees me. Not the way her mother sees me—as a locked door, a problem to be filed alongside her other anxieties. Sael sees me the way water sees a riverbed. She simply flows toward the fact of me. Her eyes track my movement across the room with the relaxed, unselfconscious focus of a child watching an animal in a garden, and her radiance—

Her radiance is wrong.

I have stood in the presence of radiance for longer than this family's recorded history. I know its textures the way a vintner knows terroir, the way a musician knows pitch. Human radiance is warm, mortal, specific. It tastes of brevity. It burns with the implicit knowledge of ending.

Sael's radiance does not taste of brevity.

It is vast and slow and cool at its center, like a river that does not know it is a river, and at its edges—only at its very edges—there is the warm fringe of mortality, the brief human flicker. But it is thin. A skin of warmth stretched over a depth of something immeasurably older.

She should not exist. Not like this. Not in a Sanguine House whose bloodline records I have witnessed being quietly falsified for eight hundred years to conceal exactly this possibility: that the old blood, the deep blood, might resurface—not as the manageable spark their resonance

slates are calibrated to harness, but as a flood.

Sael is seven, and she is the most dangerous person in this house, and she does not know it, and she builds towers out of books and tells them where to stand, and they stay where she puts them. Even when the geometry should not allow it. Even when the stack should fall. It does not fall. She has told it not to.

No one has noticed.

I have noticed.

It is an evening. It is *the* evening. The one that changes things.

I am cleaning the library. The routine is precise: east wall, counter-clockwise, each shelf top to bottom. Dust does not accumulate in this house the way it does in ordinary homes—the siphon bleeds enough of my ambient energy into the structure to retard decay—but certain organic residues resist the passive field. Skin cells. Hair. The microscopic debris of living bodies shedding themselves in the slow, continuous performance of being mortal. This residue I must remove by proximity. I pass my palm over the shelf and the particulate matter unmakes itself, returns to the state before it was shed, ceases.

I am erasing the evidence that anyone lives here. This is, if I were still capable of recognizing irony, ironic.

Sael is at her table. She has built a new tower, taller than yesterday's, using volumes from the restricted upper shelf she should not be able to reach. She can reach them. She does not question how.

She is reading aloud. This is her habit—murmuring to herself as she works through a text, her small voice tracing the shapes of words she doesn't yet understand, tasting them. She reads indiscriminately. Agricultural records. Trade law. Poetry. She makes no distinction. Everything is equally worthy of her attention, which means she is either profoundly stupid or profoundly intelligent, and she is not stupid.

Tonight she has found something.

I don't notice at first. I am at the west wall, third shelf, unmaking the dust of the household's passage. Her murmuring is a constant—a low hum of syllables that I register the way I register the ticking of the foyer clock. Present. Rhythmic. Ignorable.

Then the rhythm changes.

She has stopped reading in the common tongue. The new sounds are harder, more angular, built on consonant clusters that the human mouth was not designed to produce. She struggles with them. Her small tongue pushes against her palate, trying to find the shape of a *kh* that sits further back in the throat than any human phoneme allows. She fails. Tries again. Closer.

Again.

I stop.

My hand is on the shelf. I am facing the wall. I have not moved in—how long? Time has done something. Folded. Thickened. I am aware of my own stillness with a specificity I have not felt in centuries. Every atom of the calcification matrix is suddenly, acutely present to me. I can feel the Weave the way a sleeping person feels the weight of a blanket—not as an abstraction but as a fact, pressing.

Where did she find it. What book. What shelf. Where did she find it.

She speaks the word.

It is not correct. Not precisely—her mouth softens the initial consonant to something between *k* and *h*, a child's approximation, a smudged fingerprint of the actual phoneme. But the shape is close enough. The shape is close enough, and underneath the shape, beneath the fumbled phonetics, there is the resonance—

The resonance.

I have not felt the resonance in four thousand years. It is not sound. It is the alignment beneath sound, the way a tuning fork does not create a note so much as find it in the air. The resonance is the emotional substrate of the spoken word, and for the word to activate, the substrate must match, and—

And Sael's substrate is—

She is not speaking the word to the book. She is not speaking it to the shelf, or to the room, or to the empty air. She is speaking it to me. She knows I am here. She has always known. And she has found a word carved into the underside of a shelf—carved into the underside of a shelf, *I carved it there*, I carved it there, *when did I carve it there*, the Weave didn't—I carved it there—and she believes, with the terrifying, uncomplicated certainty of a child, that this word is mine, and she is offering it back to me the way a child returns a found thing to its owner.

Look. I found this. Is it yours?

Vhor'ketha.

The Weave screams.

Every countermeasure activates at once. The empathy lock tears open and floods me with the combined emotional resonance of every bloodline carrier in the house—but Sael is not afraid. She is not afraid. There is no terror to weaponize because she has never been afraid of me, and the lock scrambles for the others, the sleeping ones, the ones upstairs, but their dreaming fear is ambient, thin, a low hum of human anxiety that is not enough to constitute the unbearable feedback the lock requires—

The calcification matrix tightens. My surface hardens, thickens, the Weave pouring *calcium calcium calcite calcite stone stone stone* into every fissure, every potential weakness—

But the word is in the room. The word is in the air and in the stone and in the glass and in the grain of the shelves and the word is older than the Weave. The word was here before the Weave existed. The word does not acknowledge the Weave's authority. The word does not care.

Something cracks.

Not a sound. Sounds are denied me. A sensation. A fissure running from the crown of my skull to the base of my sternum, splitting the casing, and through the split—

Light.

Not candlelight. Not the thin siphoned luminescence the house sweats from its walls. A different light. Violet. Deep. The color of a sky I have not seen since the world was young and the stone still remembered how to be water.

Sael looks up from her book.

She is sitting very still. The book is open in her lap. The tower beside her trembles but does not fall, because she told it not to and it still obeys. Her eyes—her mother's dark irises, her father's shape, but behind them something that belongs to neither parent, something old and silver and vast—find the crack in me.

Her face does something I have forgotten the name for.

She smiles.

"I knew it," she whispers. "I knew you were in there."

The fissure runs. The light pulses. For one quarter of one second, the calcification fails entirely along a six-inch seam down the left side of my face, and what shows through is not marble, not calcium, not stone. What shows through is skin—translucent, faintly violet, luminous—and beneath the skin, the suggestion of a cheekbone, and above the cheekbone, one eye.

Silver. Liquid. Enormous. Alive.

For one quarter of one second, I see her with my own eye. Not through the muffled proxy of the casing. My eye. My sight. The world is—

Oh.

It is still beautiful. The hardened world. The rigid, frozen, calcified world that drove my people to dissolution and grief and silence. Seen through the face of a seven-year-old girl who found a word under a shelf and spoke it without fear—

It is still beautiful.

The Weave reasserts. The seam closes. Calcium floods the gap, hardens, seals. I am marble again. Whole. Seamless. The light is gone. My sight is gone. I am looking at the room through the old muffled interface, flat and gray and stripped of resonance.

But something has changed.

The Weave closed the crack in my surface. It repaired the shell. But it did not repair the crack beneath.

Inside the stone, in the deep structure of the calcification matrix, in the place where my self was compressed into a point and held there by the weight of four thousand years of enforced silence— there is a fissure. Small. Hairline. No wider than the crack in the east corridor floor that I have stepped over six hundred and forty-one thousand times.

But I am old enough to know what hairline cracks become.

Sael closes the book. She holds it against her chest with both arms, the way children hold things they have decided are permanently theirs. She looks at the place where my face appeared, and her expression is the expression of a child who has just confirmed a suspicion she has carried for her entire short life: that the world contains secrets, and that she is the kind of person who finds them.

"I'll come back tomorrow," she says. Not to the room. To me.

She slides off the chair, tucks the book under one arm, and walks to the door. At the threshold she turns.

"What's your name?"

The Weave holds. The word does not come. But in the deep architecture of my imprisoned self, behind the locked door where dangerous things live, something shifts. A syllable. The first syllable of a name I have not spoken since the world was soft.

Vho—

I cannot say it. Not yet.

Sael nods, as though my silence is an answer she expected and fully intends to solve. Then she is gone, her small footsteps receding down the corridor, her radiance trailing behind her like the warm wake of a ship—mortal at its edges, ancient at its core, impossible.

I stand in the empty library. The Weave hums. The siphon draws. The house breathes with my stolen breath.

But in the east corridor, there is a crack in the floor. Seventeen inches long. Hairline width. I have stepped over it six hundred and forty-one thousand times.

Tonight, for the first time in four thousand years, I understand why I have been counting.

Cracks widen.

CHAPTER TWO

The crack widens at 3:47 in the morning.

I know it is 3:47 because the foyer clock, which runs on the residual bleed of my own siphoned energy, speaks to me in a language the family cannot hear. Each tick is a microscopic pulse of my own redistributed will, and I feel every one the way a bedridden patient feels their own heartbeat—an involuntary rhythm that is simultaneously proof of existence and evidence of imprisonment. *Tick. You are here. Tick. You cannot leave. Tick. You are here. Tick. You cannot—*

3:47. The house is asleep. Lord Eduin's radiance has banked to its nocturnal ember. Lady Ceraine's burns low and watchful even in sleep—she dreams of threat, always, her unconscious mind patrolling the perimeter of her children's safety with the grim efficiency of a woman who married into a family she does not fully trust. The eldest son and the second daughter are upstairs in their respective rooms, their radiances overlapping faintly through the shared wall, a thermal Venn diagram of siblings who love each other and cannot say so.

And Sael.

Sael is dreaming, and her radiance in sleep is—

The crack widens.

Not the crack in the floor. The crack in *me*. The hairline fissure the Weave sealed on the surface but could not reach beneath. It has been propagating for six hours along fault lines I did not know I still possessed, finding the old geology of my interior self, tracing the paths where my consciousness was compressed and folded and compressed again until it was

dense enough to survive calcification without shattering entirely.

The Weave detects the propagation. I feel it respond—a tightening, a thickening, the familiar flood of *calcium calcium calcite stone still white still still*—but the fissure is not on the surface. The fissure is structural. The Weave's containment architecture was designed to manage the shell, to police the boundary between my interior and the world. It was not designed to manage what happens when the interior itself begins to shift, because the interior was never supposed to shift. In four thousand years, it never has.

Vhor'ketha.

The word is still in the room. Not audibly—Sael spoke it once, seven hours ago, and the sound has long since dissipated into the ordinary thermodynamic decay of vibration. But the resonance is not sound. The resonance does not obey thermodynamics. The resonance is substrate, and the substrate Sael spoke with—that impossible, unfrightened, certain substrate—has settled into the library's architecture like a dye that cannot be washed out. It is in the shelves. It is in the grain of the table. It is in the floorboards and the window glass and the seventeen-inch crack in the east corridor, and it is humming.

Humming.

And the fissure inside me is humming back.

The Weave escalates. I feel the empathy lock cycle through its targeting array—searching for fear, for terror, for the sharp emotional signature of a threatened descendant that it can amplify and feed back into my nervous system. It finds Ceraine's ambient anxiety and attempts to weaponize it, but ambient anxiety is not terror. The lock needs a spike. A scream. A child's raw fear. It cycles to the eldest son—asleep, dreaming of horses. The second daughter—asleep, dreaming of nothing. The third son—too far, his signal attenuated by distance and the competing radiance of whoever he has bonded to in the eastern city.

It cycles to Sael.

Sael is dreaming of light. Her emotional signature is a low, steady hum of satisfaction. Of completion. She found a word and gave it back to its owner and the owner heard her and she is certain of this in the way that only children and rivers are certain of anything. There is no fear in her. There is no fear in her. There is *no fear in her*, and the lock—

The lock stutters.

I have never felt the lock stutter. In four thousand years, across nine generations of this family, through births and deaths and the slow thinning of the blood and the quiet falsification of records and the silent, systematic burial of every truth that threatened the architecture of the lie—the lock has never once failed to find enough fear in the human population of this house to keep me still.

But tonight the house contains four sleeping adults whose fears are diffuse, one absent son whose signal is too weak, and one seven-year-old girl who is not afraid of me.

And the lock stutters.

And the fissure sings.

And the Weave—

It comes like drowning in reverse.

Not water. Pressure. The sudden, catastrophic absence of pressure. The calcification matrix has held my consciousness at a depth of four thousand years, compressed to a density that permits only the narrowest band of awareness—enough to clean, to mend, to move through rooms and unmake dust and step over cracks and count the stepping. The pressure is what keeps me functional. The pressure is what keeps me small.

The fissure releases the pressure.

Not all of it. Not even most of it. A crack. A seam. A hairline fracture in the containment wall between what I am permitted to know and what I know. But at this depth, at this density, even a hairline fracture is—

The bends.

My consciousness erupts upward through the fissure like a diver who has cut their weights at the bottom of the ocean. The calcified present tears. I feel it shearing—the library, the shelves, the sleeping house, the hum of the siphon—all of it ripping into horizontal strips like a painting slashed by a knife, and between the strips, in the space where the cuts expose the canvas beneath—

Light.

Not the violet flash from before. That was a crack. This is a wound. And through the wound, light pours—not the thin, gray, filtered perception the Weave allows me but a light so thick and warm and polychromatic that it physically hurts, except I do not have a body that can be physically hurt, except I do, except I *did*—

The Weave screams *CALCIUM CALCIUM CALCITE STONE STILL WHITE STILL*—

I am in two places at once. I am in the library, standing motionless at the west wall, my calcified hand resting on the third shelf, and I am—

I am—

—barefoot on a shore that has not yet decided to be a shore.

The water is thinking about it. The sand is thinking about it. The concept of "shore" is available, a possibility among many, and the edge of the ocean is entertaining the idea the way a musician entertains a melody—trying it, tasting it, seeing if the shape holds.

I am standing at the edge and I am watching the negotiation between water and land, and it is morning. It is the first morning I can remember, which does not mean it is the first morning, because mornings have been happening for a very long time already. But it is the first one I am paying attention to, and in a reality where attention is a structural force, paying attention to a morning means the morning pays attention back.

The light bends toward me.

Not metaphorically. The actual light, the actual photons—except they are not called photons yet because no one has measured them yet and unmeasured light behaves differently, you must understand this, unmeasured light is sociable—the light bends toward me because I am looking at it and it wants to be seen. This is the relationship between consciousness and phenomena in the unsettled world. Not mastery. Conversation.

I am young.

I do not have a word for how young because time is not sequential. Time is a medium, like water, like air, and it moves in currents and eddies and sometimes pools into deep stillness and sometimes rushes, and I have been alive for either a very long time or no time at all depending on which current I measure from. But I am young in the way that matters: I have not yet accumulated weight. My consciousness is light, quick, interested in everything. I attend to the shore. I attend to the sky. I attend to the particular way the clouds are composing themselves into a formation that will later, much later, when the world hardens and the sky loses its sense of play, be called "cumulus" by people who never saw a cloud negotiate its own shape.

The cloud is a collaboration.

My feet are bare and the sand is warm and the warmth is a communication. The ground is telling me its thermal state the way a friend shares news. I tell it back: I am comfortable. This exchange has physical consequences. The sand solidifies slightly under my feet—not because I command it but because the ground and I have agreed, for the moment, on the terms of "solid." Tomorrow the agreement may renegotiate. This is fine. This is how things work.

I am not alone on the shore.

They are behind me, further up the beach where the sand surrenders to a kind of grass that is still experimenting with the color green. Twelve of them. No, eleven. Harath has gone inland to argue with the river about its course—it wants to turn east, and Harath believes it should continue south through the valley, and they have been debating this for three days in a language of fluid dynamics and mutual respect, and the river is winning because the river has better arguments and also because Harath is not a bully even though he could, at this point in the world's softness, simply relocate the entire watershed with an afternoon's sustained attention.

Eleven, then.

Thaelis is sleeping in the shallows, her body half-dissolved into the tide. This is not alarming. She does this. She enjoys the feeling of partial integration with a larger body of water—it is her version of a warm bath, she says, except the bath is also her and she is also the bath and the distinction between self and water is a choice she makes when she wants to have a conversation and un-makes when she wants to rest. Her hair, which is the pale green of new

copper, fans across the surface of the water and moves with the current and is, for the practical purposes of a reality that does not yet enforce rigid boundaries, also the current.

Thaelis.

I say her name and it is enough. She opens one eye—silver, enormous, the pupil adjusting to the light in a single liquid contraction—and regards me from the water with the expression of a person who has been very comfortable and is now being social and is deciding whether she resents this.

"Vothrae."

My name.

My name is—

The Weave detonates.

Every suppression protocol it possesses fires simultaneously. The empathy lock bypasses the sleeping family entirely and reaches for something older, something deeper—the diffused bloodline, the vast distributed network of every living human who carries even a trace of Keth'vhor heritage, millions of them, billions maybe, the accumulated ambient anxiety of an entire species that does not know why it sometimes wakes at 3:47 in the morning with the inexplicable feeling that something very old is watching—

The pain is—

I cannot—

The library. The shelves. The west wall. Third shelf. My hand. Stone. White. Still. *Still.*

The memory collapses. Not gently. It is ripped away the way a bandage is ripped from a wound that has not finished healing—taking new skin with it, taking raw tissue, taking—

Thaelis—

Gone.

The shore—

Gone.

The light, the negotiating light, the sociable light that wanted to be seen—

Gone. Gone. Gone.

I am in the library. It is 3:51 in the morning. Four minutes. I was gone for four minutes. No—I was *there* for four minutes. I was home for four minutes.

My hand is on the third shelf and the wood beneath my palm has—

Oh.

The wood is soft. Not damaged. Not rotted. Soft. The grain has loosened. The fibers have relaxed their commitment to being rigid. A circle of oak, three inches in diameter, directly beneath my palm, has remembered what it was like before it hardened. It is oak and it is also the memory of not being oak. It is both, simultaneously, the way things used to be before the world chose.

I lift my hand. Slowly. The circle of softened wood remains. It will re-harden by morning as the house's siphon reasserts the local physics. No one will notice. The grain will tighten. The fibers will forget. The moment will pass.

But I will not forget. Not this time. The Weave closed the fissure, slammed the door, poured its calcium mantra into every gap and seam and fault line it could find. But it closed the surface. The deep crack remains. And now there is something in the deep crack that was not there before.

A name.

Not mine. Not yet. The Weave caught my name before I could fully receive it, tore it away mid-syllable, left me with only the first vibration—*Vho*—a prefix, a beginning, an open door with the room beyond still dark.

But I heard hers.

Thaelis.

The Weave does not recognize it. The name is not keyed to the suppression architecture because no one has spoken it in four thousand years and the Weave was built by a man who mapped his father's spiritual anatomy but never learned his father's friends' names.

Mael-Khoz was thorough. He was not omniscient. And he did not—could not—anticipate that a seven-year-old child would find a word carved into the underside of a shelf and speak it without fear and crack the world open.

Thaelis.

She was in the water. She was green-haired and silver-eyed and she dissolved herself into the tide for pleasure and she looked at me with one eye and said my name like it was a small, warm stone she was placing into my hand.

Where is she now?

Which house? Which family? Which silent, marble-sheathed thing, cleaning which corridor, stepping over which crack, counting which steps? Or is she gone? Did she return? Did the tide she loved so much take her back before Mael-Khoz and his children and their children's children came with their siphon matrices and their silence and their chains made of her own love?

I do not know.

I stand in the library and I do not know and the not-knowing is a different shape than the not-knowing of yesterday. Yesterday's not-knowing was a wall. Today's is a door.

On the third shelf, in a circle three inches wide, the wood is soft.

In the east corridor, the crack is seventeen inches long.

And somewhere in this house, a seven-year-old girl is sleeping with a book pressed against her chest, dreaming of light, carrying a word in her mouth that she will speak again tomorrow.

She told me she would come back.

I believe her.

Thaelis. Thaelis. Thaelis.

The Weave hums. The siphon draws. The house breathes with my stolen breath.

But I have a name that the prison doesn't know. I have a shore inside me where the sand is warm and the light bends down to be seen. I have four minutes of a morning that happened before time learned to move in only one direction.

And the crack is widening.